



theWindow

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Faith Matters: A Pursuit Worth Pursuing

Preston Graham



from the Pastor

In Isaiah 55, the prophet invites the thirsty to come to the living waters of God to be satisfied, even those who have no money! Isaiah then asks quite the provocative question: "Why do you spend your money for that which is not bread, and labor for that which does not satisfy?"

As the new year begins, there is much talk about a growing economy and hope for better days. Yet I am reminded of David Myers's book *The American Paradox: Spiritual Hunger in an Age of Plenty*. Myers observes that many of the things we often associate with the American Dream have historically not brought us the happiness we thought they would. He illustrates this observation by taking a closer look at the happiness index as related to the sexual revolution, individualism, material prosperity, etc. He asks, "has the historical pendulum swung to a point where the pursuit of pleasure is ironically amplifying misery?" In countless examples, he demonstrates how the very things that we often think will bring us happiness bring us misery. For instance, since the increased emphasis upon expressive individualism in the 60's, the divorce rate has doubled, the teen suicide rate has tripled, the violent crime rate has quadrupled, the prison population has quintupled, the percentage of babies born to unwed parents has sextupled, and depression has soared to ten times the pre-World War II level. As a pastor who deals with these sorts of things often, I can hardly stand the thought of the suffering that these statistics represent. And yet the question raised by this information is the same question raised by Isaiah a long, long time ago—why do we labor for that which does not satisfy?

When I was in the prime of my youthful ambitions, I remember very well the haunting challenge posed to me by a man who had pretty much accomplished everything he had set out to accomplish in life, which was quite a lot. It went something like this: "Perhaps the only thing worse than failure is unfettered success, for then we discover that everything we gain by success is still not enough." The point this man was impressing upon me then was the same point made by St. Augustine well over a thousand years ago when he confessed, "The heart is restless until it finds its rest in Thee."

Quoting from Isaiah 55, the last words in the New Testament speak to the increasingly insatiable thirst of our present time, and

yet the urgent invitation is extended not to the thirsty, but by the thirsty to God that he might come to them. The simple prayer went like this: "And let everyone who is thirsty say, 'Come . . . come Lord Jesus!'" As we enthusiastically embark upon our new year, here is a pursuit worth pursuing!

For those who love Christ's appearing, I would like to suggest that our pursuits will necessarily change accordingly in purpose, manners, and ultimate ends. Under the expectation of Christ's coming again, we will still pursue a career, but for the sake of a work worth doing well according to the noble dream of restoring God's creation, serving our neighbor (however local or global that neighbor may be), and courageously bearing witness to the gospel of Jesus Christ. We do these things having received what money can't buy and working for that which work cannot attain in the pursuit of things not of this world, although we remain in this world for the world. The things we pursue will include sacrificial love, sacrificial giving, and sacrificial persevering in the expectation of Christ's return. We will do these things not in order to gain life, but in the recognition that Christ has already given us life through his first coming and that he will complete his life-giving work through his second coming. We must recognize that there is nothing worth pursuing that doesn't conform to that which we gain in Christ! And until Christ returns, we should cherish even more the provisional coming that God mediates to us each week in the ministry of his word, sacraments, and fellowship as enjoyed by those who attend His church regularly. Therefore, I would encourage all of us to ask this new year about everything we do, "Is this a pursuit with pursuing?" ❖

CONTENTS



from the Pastor

Faith Matters:
A Pursuit Worth Pursuing
Preston Graham 1



Alumni Trails

An Interview with Kyle Farley
Katie Levesque 2



Music

Into Thy Light
Dan Kellogg 3



Briefings

The Graduate/Young Professional
Group
Jason Klostreich 4

An Interview with Kyle Farley

Katie Levesque



CPC has always had a young and transient congregation, and the church relishes the opportunity to train and serve those who are in town for just a few years before moving on. However, we miss those who leave and appreciate any chance to keep in touch. In that vein, the newsletter will feature an

occasional column that updates the church community about a former member and CPC's effect on his or her life. I had a chance to catch up with Kyle Farley when he visited New Haven this fall. If any of you other former CPCers out there would like to be interviewed for a future issue of the newsletter, contact me at klevesque@choate.edu. We'd love to hear from you!



Members enjoy a campfire on the fall retreat.

What brought you to New Haven originally?

I came to work on *The Works of Jonathan Edwards* in the fall of 1995 after graduating from Calvin College.

How did you find CPC?

I went to another local church for a while because someone I knew went there, and then someone asked a friend of mine to visit CPC and I went to church with him. One of my good friends was told about it and suggested that we go. Once I went to CPC, I never went anywhere else while I lived in New Haven.

What made you decide to join the church?

I liked the fact that it was a church plant because it was young and had a clear sense of mission. Often old churches have lost a sense of vision and keep doing the same things they've always done without thinking about why. CPC was young and growing and had a vitality that I found compelling. And I liked the community and Preston's preaching.

What did you most value about your experience at CPC?

The church made me become an active member of the congregation. I remember that Preston gave a sermon about being a consumer or a cultivator in the church. I hadn't really been active in any church as an adult. Preston asked why I shouldn't become a member, and I couldn't come up with a reason why not, so I joined. And the church said, you're strong—you should join the set-up team, and I did, and they said, you're friendly—you should be on the welcome team, and I was. And then I had nursery duty, as well, and suddenly I felt very invested. And when I would miss a week or two, the church would send me the bulletin in the mail, making me aware that they knew I was missing and that I was part of something. I also made some of my best friends at church.

How did the church support you in your faith and help you to grow?

Preaching and discipleship were key. Preston's sermons always gave a clear sense of how what you believe should affect the way you live. And the church also took seriously the responsibility to hold me accountable to my beliefs and check in on my life. I relished that oversight and haven't found it anywhere since. At CPC, I felt not only that I needed the church, but also that the church needed me, and that relationship was very beneficial to me.

What are you up to now?

I'm finishing a Ph.D. in American history at the University of Pennsylvania.

What do you miss most about CPC?

The community. I always looked forward to going to church and being part of a community of believers.

Have any particular lessons stuck with you from your time at CPC?

There are still some sermons that have stuck with me even years later, like the "cultivator/consumer" sermon I mentioned earlier and the "don't look for a good spouse but prepare yourself to be a good spouse" sermon. Apparently it's taking me a long time to prepare, because I'm still single. And don't tell Preston this, but I often find myself passing on advice from some of his sermons to friends. ❖



The church enjoys a fellowship meal on a beautiful fall day.

Into Thy Light

Dan Kellogg



On February 20, 2004, the New Pilgrims (the CPC band) will release their first CD, *Into Thy Light*. The album is the newest contributor to a growing movement in the Presbyterian Church in America (PCA) to revitalize traditional hymns with contemporary musical settings, a movement first initiated by the students and campus ministers of Reformed University

Fellowship. Represented on the album are not only old hymns put to new tunes (some from the RUF hymnal and a couple of our own), but also some of our most treasured hymns with their traditional melodies and a few completely new songs. The selections highlight the breadth of our worship music repertoire employed in morning and evening services and at campus gatherings.

Our CD project is on the verge of completion. In the weeks ahead the first 1,000 copies will be pressed. Trip Lehn and I have co-produced the album, which was performed by seven of our own members and three guest musicians. We recorded the album with a wonderful sound engineer at Trod Nossel Recording Studios in Wallingford. It was a large project with many unforeseen difficulties, but God's guiding hand has sustained us, and we have experienced the thrill of seeing many needs met in ways we could not have imagined.

What led us to record a worship album?! First, we are passionate about glorifying God through music and proclaiming His great redeeming acts in song. We want to offer prayers of praise, thanksgiving, and remembrance; we want to ask for God's forgiveness, healing, and sanctifying grace; we want to confess our brokenness and express our longing for the presence of God. In short, we want to worship our God!

Second, we wish to stand as witnesses to the world of the love and mercy of God in Christ. These texts proclaim the gospel, and adorned with beautiful music, they are a wonderful means of extending the gospel to a lost world. We pray that many listeners will discover the glorious gospel of Christ for the very first time, while others will grow ever more appreciative of the gospel they have embraced.

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redeeming acts in song.**

Third, we support the exciting new movement to revitalize the hymns of the church, especially those which, for various reasons, have fallen into disuse. From the earliest decades of the church, Christians have written hymns as poems of praise, many serving to fortify the theological understanding of the church. These poems were set to music and incorporated into the worship of local congregations. The greatest of these texts have endured and have been set to music time and time again as the musical

language of the culture has evolved. Following this pattern, we hope that by setting some traditional hymns to new music we can not only preserve these gems of the church, but also allow them to speak anew to the hearts of Christians today with culturally compelling music.

CD Release Party—Friday, February 20 at 7:00

At the same time, we want to connect with an ancient aspect of our faith. We should continue to worship with glorious melodies that were written hundreds of years ago and have been sung by the saints generation upon generation. We hope to remind people that our musical tradition is rich and must be passed on even as we create new songs.



CPC's musical gifts shine at the arts celebration.

Last, we want to help people worship—and not only on Sundays! God has richly blessed this congregation with a variety of talented musicians who believe that their musical service to the church is a vital dimension of their vocational calling as musicians. By producing an album, we are offering worship music that people can enjoy throughout the week. We hope people listen in their cars, in their workplaces, before home worship, or as a way to memorize some of the songs we sing regularly on Sunday morning. Please sing with us and let the words become your own prayers offered to God.

We hope you will join us Friday, February 20, at 7 p.m. for the CD Release Party! There will be great food, an outstanding concert featuring music on *Into Thy Light*, and a behind-the-scenes video documentary about the making of the album. In many ways, this party marks the beginning of the second phase of our project—promotion! We want this CD to be out in the world. Please help us to promote the CD by doing each of the following: 1) Buy copies for your non-Christian friends. What a great way to share with them an important aspect of your life (especially if they are reluctant to attend a church meeting). 2) Tell friends and family far and wide about *Into Thy Light* and be sure to refer them to our website (www.christpresnewhaven.org/cd) where they can read all about it, listen to audio samples, and order! Thank you for always encouraging us and appreciating our music, and thank you for your willingness to join us in promoting *Into Thy Light* as we together spread the gospel through song. ❖

The Graduate/Young Professional Group

Jason Klostreich



A growing and increasingly important ministry at CPC has been the activity of the Graduate/Young Professional Group. Since so many of CPC's members and regular visitors are graduate students or young people working in the area, the church desires to reach out actively to this group and help meet the needs of many of our members and visitors. This ministry has been anchored by a

Tuesday night Bible study led by Preston. The study provides an informal and valuable time not only to learn and grow in the Christian faith, but also to invite others to experience the gospel message in an informal and relaxed atmosphere with other peers.

This time together has been a great starting point that has enabled relationships to form within the group to a great degree so that fellowship can continue outside the regular meeting times on Tuesday night. The group has organized events in the past such as "dinners for eight" in which interested people were slotted to a particular home to have an enjoyable time of food and fellowship. The Graham family hosted one festive event at their home in Branford last spring. This successful evening inspired another event called the "progressive dinner" in which members

of the fellowship moved from the home one CPC member to another for appetizers, a main course, and then dessert. Other casual events during the summer included a Memorial Day get-together, a trip to Yankee Stadium for a baseball game, a 4th of July cookout, a miniature golf outing, a Labor Day cookout, and of course beach volleyball. This fall, the group sponsored a back-to-school event within the first weeks of the academic year to welcome new visitors to the church to help them get connected to the CPC family. The fellowship also held a Caribbean night full of food, fun, and flip flops. More recently, the group planned a fall festival for the children of the church, complete with games, snacks, and crafts.

This year the schedule for the Tuesday night Bible study changed somewhat because the group felt that it would be important to include more time for prayer and sharing in addition to the Bible study. Since having all this on one night would be a lot in one evening, Preston now teaches one Tuesday night and then on alternating Tuesday nights the group meets for announcements, singing, prayer, and reflection on the recent teachings of the study. The meetings have been well attended and we are expecting to continue to grow as the word gets out. At present we are going through the epistle to the Galatians, which is already proving to be a spiritual bombshell! Many new people have found our group this year and attend regularly, and we expect to share more exciting news in the near future as we look forward to the greatness of God working in the lives of His people. ❖



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